

# Trying out the Nurosym vagus nerve stimulator for a couple of weeks

**Cite as:** Martin Paul Eve, "Trying out the Nurosym vagus nerve stimulator for a couple of weeks", *eve.gd: Martin Paul Eve*, August 24, 2025, <https://doi.org/10.59348/az6ev-rvh24>.

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A really good measure of how wrecked you are is your body's "heart rate variability" (HRV). This is the difference between the gap between your heart beats. So if you imagine: BEAT (GAP) BEAT (GAP) BEAT (GAP), HRV is the difference of length of those gaps. Strangely, and counter-intuitively, a low (and therefore more regular) HRV is worse. When the beat is less regular, the heart has more slack to combat stress, whereas if it's totally rigid and regimented already, then it's operating at a stressed level.

As a patient with end-stage renal failure, rheumatoid arthritis, IBD, previous stroke, high blood pressure, severe immunodeficiency, mitochondrial disease (MELAS) and more, my body is under a lot of stress. There has also been a lot of medical research into the role the vagus nerve plays in the inflamed body. Just a short while ago, [a vagus nerve implant passed trials in the US for rheumatoid arthritis treatment](#). This is to the great delight of many trauma counsellors, who have based their practice on the notion of the nervous system having sympathetic and para-sympathetic states, [mediated by the vagus nerve](#). It has long been thought that if we could switch the state of the nervous system from fight/flight to rest/recuperate, using the vagus nerve, then we would be able to reduce chronic inflammation cycles and improve wellbeing... all of which might well be reflected in HRV. Now, I'm less convinced by this side of things – sorry, but I want some hard numbers and medical theory. However, [it does seem that there are scientific papers on this](#).

The Nurosym, made by Parasym Ltd, is an external vagus nerve stimulator that administers a gentle buzzing by clipping on to the tragus in your ear. You basically clip the device to your ear for 30-60 minutes per day and it then does its little tingly thing, charging you up to improve sleep or to supercharge your day. Well, that's the theory, anyway. I've been trying it for a couple of weeks – at a time when I am actually very unwell with a chest infection – so I was keen to see what it could do. I was also acutely aware that I really WANTED this to work; I was feeling lousy and wanted a result.

I've been taking baseline and test results using my Garmin Fenix 6 watch and, to be honest, the results are quite pronounced and impressive. *Yes*, my HRV is going up in a way that it hasn't for several years now. My sleep scores are consistently improved on the nights I've used it. On the other hand, when I forgot, they slid back down again. So far, in my testing, the device seems genuine. Of course, this could be a subconscious placebo. I'm not ruling that out. But it is interesting.

So, on that front, I am sold. It's impressive! I do have a few smaller gripes, though. The fitting is fiddly and requires you to stay *very* still while using the device (at least for me). I have to readjust the device several times during a 30 minute session, or even hold it in place. I also cannot wear my specs while using the Nurosym, so reading is also out of the question. I can just about watch TV while using it, but you need almost to bank on having a 30-60 minute electro-meditation time where you dedicate yourself to the device each day. It's doable, but just frustrating. The device is also expensive! There are second-hand ones on Ebay, but I fancied a clean one that hadn't seen previous tragus-action. I am guessing, cost-wise, that it takes a lot to get to the point where you can shift these units in enough of a volume to make money.

I must say that I was quite annoyed by their “scientific evidence” page. I just wanted a bibliography and, specifically, to know which papers THEIR TEAM had published. It just really links to pages about vagus nerve research in general. I *think* that this article may be the medical study protocol, but it's hard to tell. Finally, I've heard bad things about their customer support. But I contacted them and got a (admittedly, copy and pasted) reply.

I will continue to use the Nurosym and to see whether my HRV continues to improve. So far, I am pretty impressed!

I was not paid for this review.

## References

1. Geng, Duyan, and others, 'The Effect of Transcutaneous Auricular Vagus Nerve Stimulation on HRV in Healthy Young People', PLOS ONE, 17.2 (2022), p. e0263833, <https://doi.org/10.1371/journal.pone.0263833>
2. Azabou, Eric, and others, 'Randomized Cross Over Study Assessing the Efficacy of Non-Invasive Stimulation of the Vagus Nerve in Patients With Axial Spondyloarthritis Resistant to Biotherapies: The ESNV-SPA Study Protocol', Frontiers in Human Neuroscience, 15 (2021), <https://doi.org/10.3389/fnhum.2021.679775>